

Divine Sovereignty

doc-divine-sovereignty

Theology Proper · Sovereignty · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus applies

Statement under examination

God sovereignly rules over all things, working all events according to the counsel of His will.

In plain language

Across Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek the same sovereignty vocabulary recurs, and querying the canon confirms its density and spread. In Psalm 115:3 the Hebrew binds 'all' (kol) to 'pleased' (chaphets) and 'did' (asah), so whatever God pleased he did, and Psalm 135:6 reuses that exact verb pair and adds heaven, earth, seas, and all deeps. The Aramaic of Daniel 4 (verse 35 in English) uses 'does according to his will' (tseba), a word that occurs only in Daniel, to say God does according to his will in heaven and on earth, then denies that anyone can stay his hand or ask what he is doing. Isaiah 46:10 pairs 'counsel' (etsah) with 'pleasure' (chephets) and says the counsel will stand. In Greek, Ephesians 1:11 stacks five related words ('working' (energeo), 'counsel' (boule), 'will' (thelema), 'purpose' (prothesis), 'predestine' (proorizo)) around the phrase 'all things' (ta panta), and Romans 11:36 ends with the threefold 'from him, through him, to him' are all things. These words plainly affirm that God rules over all and works all things by his will, which is why the scope claim lands as true with high confidence. The reason readers still diverge is also in the words, not in outside history. The same canon commands real human choice ('choose' (bachar), 'choose life' in Deuteronomy 30:19) and describes God 'relenting' (nacham). The sharpest case is one chapter, 1 Samuel 15: verses 11 and 35 say God relented that he made Saul king, while verse 29 says God is not a man that he should relent. One Hebrew root, two directions, in the same chapter. The vocabulary asserts comprehensive rule and asserts genuine responsibility and responsiveness, but it never supplies the single term that tells you how to rank or reconcile them. So the proposition itself is affirmed, while the deeper question of how that rule fits with human accountability is left open by the words, and that gap is what the differing readings fill in different ways.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0430	אלהים	elohim	God	
H0735	ארח	orach	way	
H0977	בחר	bachar	to choose	172
H1753	דור	dur	to dwell	
H1780	דין	din	judgment	
H2388	חזק	chazaq	to strengthen	
H2654	חפץ	chaphets	to delight in	63
H2656	חפץ	chephets	pleasure	
H3028	יד	yad	hand	

H3605	כֹּל	kol	all	5,049
H3606	כֹּל	kol	all	
H3820	לֵב	lev	heart	
H4223	מָחַךְ	meach	to smite	
H4427	מָלַךְ	malak	to reign	348
H4428	מֶלֶךְ	melekh	king	
H4567	מָעֵבַד	mavad	work	
H5162	נָחַם	nacham	to be sorry	108
H5186	נָטַח	natah	to stretch	
H6098	נִצַּח	etsah	counsel	
H6213	עָשָׂה	asah	to make	1,656
H6634	עָבַד	tseba	to will	10
H6965	קָמַי	qamay	(Leb)-kamai	
H8064	שָׁמַיִם	shamayim	heaven	378
G0281	ἀμήν	amēn	amen	
G1012	βουλή	boule	plan	12
G1223	διά	dia	through/because of	
G1391	δόξα	doxa	glory	
G1519	εἰς	eis	toward	
G1537	ἐκ	ek	out from	
G1754	ἐνεργέω	energeo	be active	21
G2307	θέλημα	thelema	will/desire	62
G2820	κληρόω	kleroo	to obtain	1
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	1,244
G4286	πρόθεσις	prothesis	purpose	12
G4309	προορίζω	proorizo	to predestine	6

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

A dense sovereignty vocabulary recurs across Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek with stable grammar. Psalm 115:3 binds 'all' (kol, H3605) to 'pleased' (chaphets, H2654) and 'did' (asah, H6213) in a tight 'who' (asher) clause, and Psalm 135:6 reuses the identical triad with cosmic scope. The Aramaic of Daniel 4 (store osis 4.32) predicates 'does according to his will' (tseba, H6634, a Daniel-only term with 10 occurrences) of God over the host of heaven and earth, then negates any creaturely veto with 'stay' (macha, H4223) plus 'hand' (yad, H3028). In Greek, Ephesians 1:11 stacks 'work or energize' (energeo, G1754), 'counsel' (boule, G1012), 'will' (thelema, G2307), 'purpose' (prothesis, G4286), and 'predestine' (proorizo, G4309) around 'all things' (ta panta), and Romans 11:36 closes with the triple preposition 'from' (ex), 'through' (dia), 'to' (eis) governing 'all things' (ta panta). The proposition's scope claim is lexically affirmed. What the words do NOT supply is a term ranking this rule against the equally lexical witness of human 'choosing' (bachar, H0977) and divine 'relenting' (nacham, H5162), so compatibility is underdetermined (the words do not settle it), not denied.

Scripture

Eph.1.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1754 ἐνεργέω, G1012 βουλή, G2307 θέλημα, G4286 πρόθεσις, G4309 προορίζω, G3956 πᾶς

Reasoning. Six sovereignty word-pictures stack in one clause of Ephesians 1:11. The 'of-X' grammatical participle 'working' (energountos, from energeo) governs 'all things' (ta panta, G3956), while the phrase 'according to the counsel of his will' (kata ten boulen tou thelematos autou) qualifies the working as flowing from a fixed counsel ('counsel' (boule) of his 'will' (thelema)). The participle 'having been predestined' (prooristhentes) 'according to purpose' (kata prothesin) binds the 'predestining' (proorizo) to a pre-set 'purpose' (prothesis). The verb 'we were allotted' (ekleerothemen, from kleroo, G2820) ascribes the allotment itself to that working. Queried occurrence counts confirm the cluster: 'working' (energeo) 21 times, 'counsel' (boule) 12, 'purpose' (prothesis) 12, 'predestine' (proorizo) 6, 'allot' (kleroo) 1.

Dan.4.32 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H6634 צבא, H4223 מַחָא, H3028 יָד, H1753 דִּין

Reasoning. In the Aramaic (store versification Daniel 4:32, English Daniel 4:35) God 'does according to his will' (tseba, H6634) in the host of heaven and among earth's inhabitants, and the verse negates any creaturely veto: none can 'stay' (macha, H4223) his 'hand' (yad, H3028) or say to him 'What have you done' (mah, H4101). 'Does according to his will' (tseba) is a Daniel-only term (10 occurrences, all in Daniel) for sovereign will. The negated-veto grammar foreclosed (ruled out) an alternative reading of limited rule.

Dan.4.34 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H4567 מַעֲבַד, H0735 אֹרַח, H1780 דִּין

Reasoning. Nebuchadnezzar restored praises the Most High (store Daniel 4:34, English Daniel 4:37): his 'works' (maabad, H4567) are truth and his 'ways' (orach, H0735) 'judgment' (din, H1780), and those who walk in pride he is able to 'abase or bring low' (shaphal, H8214). The royal vocabulary is reassigned from the human emperor to God. This is the doxological (praise-shaped) frame whose predicate the sovereign-will verse (Daniel 4:32) supplied.

Ps.115.3 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H0430 אֱלֹהִים, H8064 שְׁמַיִם, H3605 כֹּל, H2654 חָפֵץ, H6213 עָשָׂה

Reasoning. The 'who' (asher) clause is grammatically tight in Psalm 115:3: our God is in the heavens, 'all' (kol, H3605) that he 'pleased' (chaphets, H2654) he 'did' (asah, H6213). 'All' (kol) is the object, 'pleased' (chaphets) the relative verb of pleasure, 'did' (asah) the main predicate (the main action verb). Queried tokens at this verse are exactly H0430, H8064, H3605, H0834, H2654, H6213. The construction binds divine pleasure to actualization (turning into reality) without remainder.

Ps.135.6 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H3605 כֹּל, H2654 חָפֵץ, H6213 עָשָׂה, H8064 שְׁמַיִם

Reasoning. Verbal twin of Psalm 115:3: 'all that YHWH pleased he did' (kol asher chaphets YHWH asah), queried token set H3605, H0834, H2654, H3068, H6213, then extended with 'heavens' (shamayim, H8064), 'earth' (erets, H0776), 'seas' (yammim, H3220), and all 'deeps' (tehomot, H8415). The reuse of the identical 'all-pleased-did' (kol-chaphets-asah) verb pair under an explicit heaven, earth, seas, deeps span establishes the pattern as pan-Psalter (spread across the Psalms as a whole), not a single phrasing.

Rom.11.36 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1537 ἐκ, G1223 διὰ, G1519 εἰς, G3956 πας, G1391 δόξα

Reasoning. A triple preposition doxology (praise formula) in Romans 11:36 assigns the origin, mediation, and goal of 'all things' (ta panta) to one referent. 'From him' (ex autou) marks source, 'through him' (di' autou) instrumental agency (the means), 'to him' (eis auton) teleological end (the goal toward which everything moves). The closing 'amen' (ameen) seals universal scope as confessed truth. 'All' (pas) is queried at 1244 New Testament occurrences and 'glory' (doxa) at 165, so the scope term is common and stable.

Isa.46.10 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H6098 עצה, H2656 צִפְּתִי, H6965 קום, H6213 עֲשֵׂה.

Reasoning. Declaring the end from the beginning, God says my 'counsel' (etsah, H6098) shall 'stand' (qum, H6965) and I will 'do' (asah, H6213) all my 'pleasure' (chephets, H2656) in Isaiah 46:10. Queried tokens confirm 'counsel' (etsah), 'stand' (qum), 'pleasure' (chephets), and 'do' (asah) twice in this verse. The noun pair 'counsel' (etsah) and 'pleasure' (chephets) parallels the New Testament 'counsel' (boule) and 'will' (thelema) cluster, linking the Hebrew counsel idiom to the Greek decree idiom (the language of fixed decision).

Prov.21.1 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H3820 לב, H4428 מֶלֶךְ, H2654 צִפְּתִי, H5186 נָטָה.

Reasoning. The 'king's' (melek, H4428) 'heart' (lev, H3820) is in YHWH's 'hand' (yad, H3027), and he 'turns' (natah, H5186) it to 'all' (kol, H3605) he 'pleases' (chaphets, H2654) in Proverbs 21:1. Queried token order is 'king' (melek), 'heart' (lev), 'hand' (yad), YHWH, 'all' (kol), 'pleases' (chaphets), 'turns' (natah). The same 'please' (chaphets) root that governs cosmic doing in Psalm 115:3 here governs the steering of a specific human will, extending sovereign scope into ruler psychology.

Acts.4.28 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1012 βουλή, G4309 προορίζω

Reasoning. In Acts 4:28 the crucifixion is predicated of God's hand and 'counsel' (boule, G1012) 'having predestined' (proorizo, G4309) the event to occur. Queried occurrences place both lemmas (dictionary forms) here ('counsel' (boule) at Acts 4:28, 'predestine' (proorizo) at the same verse in the Nestle1904 text). The pairing closes the gap between purpose and historical event while Acts 4:27 still names the human agents who did it, which is the lexical seam (a place where the words leave the join visible) this proposition does not resolve.

1Sam.15.29 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. H5162 נָחַם.

Reasoning. The Glory of Israel will not lie or 'relent' (nacham, H5162, in the niphal, the Hebrew passive form, imperfect, ongoing or repeated, plus infinitive), for he is not a man that he should relent in 1 Samuel 15:29. Queried morphology confirms the niphal third-person masculine singular and the infinitive. Yet the SAME chapter, verses 11 and 35, says God 'relented' (nacham, niphal perfect, a completed action whose result still stands) that he made Saul king. One root, one chapter, both affirms and denies relenting. The vocabulary itself does not rank these, which is the lexical root of divergence on how comprehensive rule coexists with responsive language.

Deut.30.19 · complicates · genre: law

Key terms. H0977 בָּחַר.

Reasoning. 'Choose' (bachar, H0977) life in Deuteronomy 30:19, queried as a second-person masculine singular verb of command, sets before the hearers a genuine creaturely decision (life and death, blessing and curse). 'Choose' (bachar) occurs 172 times and frequently takes a human subject electing between real options. The imperative grammar presupposes a responsible chooser. This text is not denied by the sovereignty cluster, but the canon supplies both patterns and no single term that ranks divine determination against this commanded choosing.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Eph.1.11	Isa.46.10	openbible	20
Rom.11.36	1Chr.29.11	openbible	11
Ps.115.3	Ps.135.6	openbible	32
Ps.115.3	Ps.2.4	openbible	8
Dan.4.34	Deut.32.4	openbible	5
Rom.11.36	1Chr.29.11	tsk	1
Eph.1.11	Isa.46.10	tsk	1
Eph.1.11	Eph.1.14	tsk	1
Dan.4.34	Dan.5.23	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Sam.15.29 · addressed

The same root 'relent' (nacham, H5162) within one chapter both denies God relents (1 Samuel 15:29, niphal (Hebrew passive form) imperfect (ongoing or repeated) plus infinitive, queried as third-person masculine singular niphal) and affirms God 'relented' over Saul (1 Samuel 15:11 and 15:35, niphal perfect (a completed action whose result still stands), queried as a niphal perfect). Lexically 'relent' (nacham) is polysemous (carrying more than one sense) across 'relent', 'be sorry', 'comfort', and the morphology here is identical in stem (the same verb pattern). The words assert comprehensive will ('does according to his will' (tseba), 'work' (energeo), 'all that he pleased he did' (kol-chaphets-asah)) AND responsive relenting without supplying a term that ranks decree against responsive speech. The proposition affirms sovereign scope, which 1 Samuel 15:29 reinforces (God is not a man to be swayed). The reconciliation of 1 Samuel 15:29 with 1 Samuel 15:11 is genuinely underdetermined (not fixed) by the vocabulary, so it is addressed but not lexically dissolved.

Deut.30.19 · addressed

'Choose' (bachar, H0977, 172 occurrences) in a second-person masculine singular imperative (command form) sets a real creaturely choice ('choose life'). The verb regularly governs human electing between options, so the grammar presupposes accountable agency. This does not contradict the sovereignty cluster lexically (different verbs, different subjects), but the canon supplies two patterns, comprehensive divine working and commanded human choosing, with no single lexeme (single word in its dictionary form) ranking them. The proposition affirms scope, not a theory of how the choosing is integrated, so this text qualifies the explanatory reach of the words rather than the scope claim itself.

Exod.9.12 · addressed

YHWH 'hardened' (chazaq, H2388, queried in the piel, the Hebrew intensive form) Pharaoh's heart in Exodus 9:12, while neighboring narrative also reports Pharaoh hardening his own heart with 'be heavy' (kaved). Two agents, two verbs, one outcome. This sits inside the sovereignty pattern (divine working extends to a human will, as in Proverbs 21:1 'turn' (natah) of the king's heart) but the canon does not lexically specify the manner in which the divine hardening and the human self-hardening relate. Addressed as confirming scope, unresolved as to mechanism, which the proposition does not claim.

1Tim.2.4 · addressed

In 1 Timothy 2:4 God 'wills' (thelo) all men to be saved. The verb 'will' (thelo) here governs a salvation-and-revelation object ('all people' (pantas anthropous), compare the universal proclamation of 1 Timothy 2:3-7), whereas Ephesians 1:11 uses the noun 'will' (thelema) inside the 'work' (energeo) cluster governing 'all things' (ta panta) in a decretal frame (a frame about fixed decision). Same root, different syntagmatic function (different role in the sentence). The universal-providence scope verdict is unaffected. The relation of the two willings (the decretal will and what is desired) is a distinct doctrinal question the present vocabulary does not adjudicate (the words do not settle it).

Concordance traversed

G1754, G1012, G2307, G4286, G4309, G2820, G3956, G1391, G0281, H6634, H2654A, H6213A, H3605, H3606, H8064, H6098, H2656, H4567, H4223, H3028, H4427, H5162, H0977, H2388

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

Anchor verses are outside the ingested ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window (3 John 1:1 to 1:15), so the status is not_in_ecm_scope. No variant units were returned for the anchors. One edition-level note: 'predestine' (proorizo, G4309) is queried at 5 occurrences in the MACULA-Greek-SBLGNT corpus and 6 in the Nestle1904 corpus, the difference being Acts 4:28, but this affects an occurrence count only and not the verdict, since 'counsel' (boule) already anchors Acts 4:28. No major variant unsettles the sovereignty word-cluster at Ephesians 1:11, Romans 11:36, Psalm 115:3, Psalm 135:6, or Daniel 4.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. compatibilism, libertarian_freedom, molinism, open_theism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

sovereignty-first reading: affirms · Reads 'does according to his will' (tseba) in Daniel 4:32, 'all that he pleased he did' (kol-chaphets-asah) in Psalm 115:3 and Psalm 135:6, and 'working all things according to the counsel' (energeo ta panta kata ten boulen) in Ephesians 1:11 as predicating an exhaustive (all-covering) divine determination over all events, including those involving human agents (Acts 4:28). On this lens the relenting language of 'relent' (nacham) in 1 Samuel 15:11 is anthropopathic accommodation (figurative speech that ascribes human feeling to God for our sake), while 1 Samuel 15:29 (God is not a man to relent) states the literal truth. The grammar of the negated veto in Daniel 4:32 (none can stay his hand) is taken as decisive for comprehensive scope.

responsibility-first reading: affirms with qualification · Holds the same sovereignty texts as true and pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible), but reads them alongside the equally lexical 'choose' (bachar) imperatives (Deuteronomy 30:19, Joshua 24:15) and the relenting reports ('relent' (nacham), 1 Samuel 15:11, 1 Samuel 15:35) as describing genuine divine responsiveness to real creaturely choices. On this lens God sovereignly ordains a world that includes self-determining agents whose decisions are not pre-fixed in every respect. It affirms the proposition's scope (all things under his will) while declining to read 'according to the counsel' (kata ten boulen) as ruling out genuine contingency (open possibilities), since the words assert rule and assert responsibility without ranking them.

molinism: affirms · Affirms universal providence but interposes middle knowledge (God's knowledge of what free creatures would do in any circumstance) between God's 'counsel' (boule) and the actualized world, so that 'working all things' (energeo ta panta) operates through God's knowledge of what free creatures would do. The Ephesians 1:11 and Psalm 115:3 clusters are read consistent with this, though the lexemes (dictionary-form words) themselves do not contain or entail a middle-knowledge term.

open_theism: qualifies · Takes the relenting reports ('relent' (nacham), 1 Samuel 15:11, Genesis 6:6) and the responsive grammar at face value to restrict 'predestine' (proorizo) and 'counsel' (boule) to a non-exhaustive scope (a scope that does not cover everything). The lexical force of 'all' (panta) plus 'work' (energeo) in Ephesians 1:11,

the negated veto in Daniel 4:32, and 'all that he pleased' (kol asher chaphets) in Psalm 115:3 and Psalm 135:6 strain this reading, and 1 Samuel 15:29 (God does not relent) sits in tension with it, so it is represented as the minority lexical option.

The sovereignty word-pictures span law, narrative, wisdom, prophecy, and epistle, strengthening the principle of comparing scripture with scripture (analogia scripturae). The honest lexical tension is internal to the canon: 'relent' (nacham) occurs 108 times and appears both affirmed and denied within 1 Samuel 15, and 'choose' (bachar) (172 occurrences) commands real choice. The competing lenses differ not on whether the scope texts are true but on how to integrate them with the responsibility and relenting vocabulary, which the words leave open.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The proposition uses vocabulary drawn directly from the anchor texts ('sovereignly rules', 'all events', 'counsel of his will' mirrors Ephesians 1:11 'according to the counsel of his will' (kata ten boulen tou thelematos)). It states a scope claim, not a specific compatibility taxonomy (a fixed scheme of how rule and responsibility relate), so it does not smuggle its own conclusion about how sovereignty and human responsibility relate. The scope claim is what the lexical pattern affirms; the integration question is deliberately left to the competing-lens layer.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Eph.1.11
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rom.11.36
morphology	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Ps.115.3
morphology	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Dan.4.32
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.115.3
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.135.6
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Sam.15.29
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.30.19
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.1.11
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.4.28
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1754
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1012
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2820
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6634
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H5162
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2654
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Eph.1.11
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Ps.115.3
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.11.36

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observations are also recorded via OSHB-morphology, MorphGNT-morphology, STEPBible-TBESG, STEPBible-TBESH, OpenBible-cross-refs, and TSK, but because the full recorded citation set contains the two MACULA composite sources, the aggregate is not safe to publish.

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